
From Noise to Diversity: Random Embedding Injection in LLM Reasoning

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Abstract

Recent *soft prompt* research has tried to improve reasoning by inserting trained vectors into LLM inputs, yet whether the gain comes from the *learned content* or from the *act of injection itself* has not been carefully separated. We study Random Soft Prompts (RSPs), which drop the training step entirely and append a freshly drawn sequence of random embedding vectors to the input. Each RSP vector is sampled from an isotropic Gaussian fitted to the entrywise mean and variance of the pretrained embedding table; the sequence carries no learned content, and yet matches the accuracy of trained *soft prompts* on math reasoning benchmarks. The mechanism unfolds in two stages: because attention has to absorb a never-seen-before random position, the distribution over the first few generated tokens flattens and reasoning trajectories *branch*, and as generation continues this influence dilutes naturally so the response *converges toward the goal*. We show that during inference RSPs lift early-stage token diversity and, combined with temperature sampling, widen Pass@ N , the probability that at least one out of N attempts is correct. Beyond inference, we carry the same effect into DAPO training and demonstrate practical gains. Our contributions are: (i) a new finding that purely training-free random embedding injection alone drives latent reasoning; (ii) a theoretical and empirical validation of the underlying mechanism; and (iii) an extension from inference to training.  <https://github.com/rsp-anon-2026/RandomSoftPrompt>

1 Introduction

This work began from an observation made while studying *soft prompts* for LLM reasoning: even *untrained*, randomly drawn embeddings can recover accuracy and reshape early decoding in several settings, with no optimization. As LLMs scale, full fine-tuning is prohibitive, motivating parameter-efficient methods [Hu et al., 2022, Houlsby et al., 2019]. Among these, *soft prompts* insert learnable continuous embeddings into the input, steering behavior through attention [Li and Liang, 2021, Lester et al., 2021]; this paradigm is actively adopted for mathematical reasoning [Kang et al., 2026, Xu et al., 2025, Ye et al., 2026, Hao et al., 2025, Zhang et al., 2026]. These methods share a common structure — inject out-of-vocabulary continuous embeddings and *optimize* them — and prior work generally attributes the gains to the trained values, leaving the structural effect of injection itself unexamined.

To separate *learned content* from the *act of injection*, we use Random Soft Prompts (RSPs) as a control — continuous vectors drawn from an isotropic Gaussian fitted to the embedding table’s mean and variance, with no learning. The control turns out to be non-neutral. Applying a chat template to a base model not fine-tuned for it degrades reasoning, yet appending RSPs recovers up to +29 pp on Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B; if simple noise were merely shaking the model, accuracy should have worsened instead. The injection itself, independent of any learned content, alters model behavior. Existing

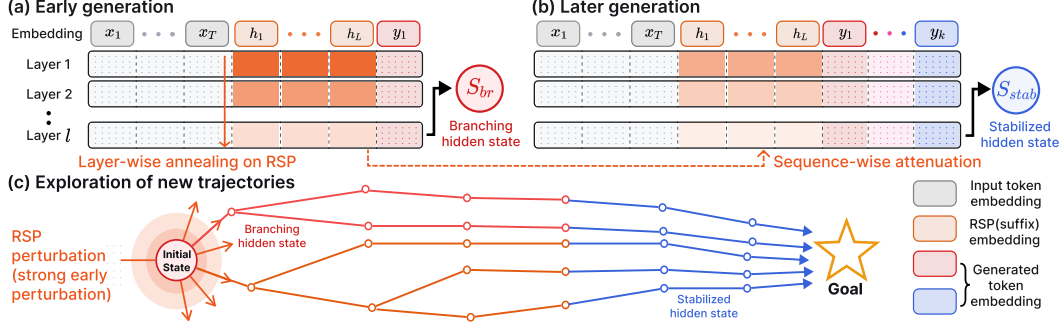


Figure 1: Conceptual overview of RSP-induced trajectory diversity. The hidden states shown are the final-layer outputs that drive the next-token distribution. (a) Early decoding: RSP perturbation reaches a *branching state* (red; formalized in §3.1), whose top- K differs from the no-RSP baseline and induces a diverse output distribution. (b) Later decoding: as the KV cache grows, the bound on RSP attention mass narrows (Theorem 1); branching events become rare and the hidden state (blue) commits to the branch already opened. (c) Across rollouts, the trajectories opened by early RSP perturbation accumulate into independent paths that converge to goal-directed completions.

37 studies focus on end-task accuracy and have not separated injection effects from optimization, leaving
38 how embedding injection reshapes the output distribution insufficiently explored.

39 We analyze training-free Random Soft Prompts (RSPs) on LLM reasoning. With each rollout
40 receiving an *independent* draw, a single RSP injection *branches* hidden states into diverse trajectories
41 early on, which then *stabilize* into goal-directed completions. Empirically, RSPs share the early-
42 decoding entropy signature of optimized methods (LTPO, TTSV, SoftCoT) despite carrying no learned
43 content; Pass@ N accumulates only under *independent* resampling; and the same input-side diversity
44 composes with DAPO [Yu et al., 2025] training. Our contributions are: (i) untrained RSP serves as a
45 *non-neutral control* that disentangles *learned content* from the *act of injection*, reaching a comparable
46 range to optimized *soft prompts* in several settings and suggesting part of what trained methods deliver
47 is a structural by-product of injection; (ii) a theoretical and empirical account of the mechanism
48 (attention-mediated branch opening, isotropic directional coverage, KV-cache attenuation); and (iii)
49 DAPO extension showing independent RSP resampling composes with rollout-diversity training.

50 2 Background

51 2.1 Soft Prompt Methods for LLM Reasoning

52 Prior *soft prompt* methods all share a common structure: they inject out-of-vocabulary continuous
53 embeddings and *optimize* them under task-specific objectives. Because evaluation is anchored to
54 end-task accuracy, the contributions of “injection itself” and “optimization” are not separated, and
55 how plain embedding injection reshapes model behavior remains an open question. As parameter-
56 efficient alternatives to full fine-tuning, Prefix-Tuning [Li and Liang, 2021], Prompt Tuning [Lester
57 et al., 2021], and P-tuning [Liu et al., 2024] reached near-fine-tuning performance using learnable
58 continuous vectors, after which LLM-reasoning-specific variants quickly followed. TTSV [Kang
59 et al., 2026] optimizes *prefix* embeddings at test time via trajectory entropy minimization; SoftCoT
60 [Xu et al., 2025] replaces explicit chain-of-thought tokens with soft tokens generated by an assistant
61 model; LTPO [Ye et al., 2026] optimizes the *soft prompt* per problem to maximize its own confidence
62 on that problem; COCONUT [Hao et al., 2025] feeds the model’s own hidden states back as input
63 embeddings; MemGen [Zhang et al., 2026] uses embedding vectors as experience memory; and
64 Pause tokens [Goyal et al., 2024] insert learnable tokens to provide additional computation steps.

65 2.2 Noise Injection in Neural Networks

66 Neural networks have incorporated noise at several stages and locations. During training, dropout
67 [Srivastava et al., 2014] randomly deactivates *hidden activations*, and NEFTune [Jain et al., 2024]
68 adds Gaussian noise to *input embeddings* during instruction fine-tuning to improve instruction

69 following. At inference time, randomized smoothing [Cohen et al., 2019] injects Gaussian noise into
 70 *raw inputs* to obtain certified robustness, and SmoothLLM [Robey et al., 2025] perturbs prompts at
 71 the *discrete character* level to defend against jailbreaking. In RL, NoisyNet [Fortunato et al., 2018]
 72 *adds* learnable, trained noise to *network weights* to aid exploration.

73 RSP *appends* noise to *embeddings*, and differs from these in three respects. (1) It operates without
 74 any training, purely at inference, and does not modify model parameters (unlike dropout, NEFTune,
 75 and NoisyNet). (2) It preserves the original input and appends the embedding within a single forward
 76 pass, so it does not require the “multiple noisy passes plus aggregation” that robustness methods
 77 need. (3) It uses vectors drawn directly from the pretrained embedding statistics, with no learned
 78 parameters at all (NoisyNet, by contrast, learns its noise parameters).

79 3 Random Soft Prompts and Why They Work

80 RSP enters the hidden state through self-attention rather than directly, so within one attention head the
 81 magnitude envelope of its instantaneous contribution is controlled by one scalar: the *attention mass*
 82 w on RSP tokens. We track how w evolves during decoding. Early on, w is large enough to branch
 83 the hidden state into multiple directions (§3.2); as the KV cache grows, its upper bound narrows and
 84 the response converges (§3.3). Randomness supplies *independent* perturbations across rollouts so
 85 each opens a fresh branch (further proofs in Appendix D).

86 3.1 Random Soft Prompt

87 We start with the object being analyzed. Let $\mathbf{W}_E \in \mathbb{R}^{V \times d}$ denote the pretrained token-embedding
 88 matrix, with V the vocabulary size and d the hidden dimension. Write its entrywise statistics as
 89 $\mu_E := \frac{1}{V \cdot d} \sum_{i,k} [\mathbf{W}_E]_{i,k}$ (the mean over all $V \cdot d$ entries) and $\sigma_E := \text{std}(\mathbf{W}_E)$. An RSP of length
 90 L is a sequence of continuous vectors $\mathbf{H} = [h_1, \dots, h_L] \in \mathbb{R}^{L \times d}$ drawn independently from

$$h_j \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_E \mathbf{1}_d, \sigma_E^2 \mathbf{I}_d), \quad j = 1, \dots, L. \quad (1)$$

91 The centered form $\bar{h}_j := h_j - \mu_E \mathbf{1}_d \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_E^2 \mathbf{I}_d)$ is a zero-mean isotropic Gaussian. Letting
 92 $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{T \times d}$ denote the input token-embedding sequence (the T rows of $\mathbf{W}_E$ corresponding to the
 93 prompt tokens), the main text uses the *suffix* form $[\mathbf{X}; \mathbf{H}] \in \mathbb{R}^{(T+L) \times d}$ as the default; other positions
 94 (*prefix*, *infix* [Kang et al., 2026, Xu et al., 2025, Ye et al., 2026, Zhang et al., 2026]) are reported as
 95 ablations in §4.2 and Appendix A. RSP is not a learnable parameter, so it receives no gradient and is
 96 freshly drawn for each rollout.

97 Call decoding step t a *branching event* and the last-layer hidden state $\mathbf{s}^{(t)}$ a *branching state* when
 98 the LM-head top- K differs from that of the no-RSP baseline $\bar{\mathbf{s}}^{(t)}$ (Figure 1, red).¹ §3.2 asks *when* a
 99 branching event is reachable, and §3.3 asks *how* that reachability fades.

100 3.2 Exploration: RSP strengthens early-stage exploration

101 Inserting a random prompt concentrates attention on it, and that concentration is what amplifies
 102 exploration. The effect of a single injection on the hidden state raises two questions — *how much*
 103 and *where* — decided respectively by the scalar w inside one attention head and by the distribution of
 104 $\mathbf{H}$. The isotropic Gaussian addresses both at once.

105 Consider one attention head in self-attention layer ℓ . At query position i , the query attends $n \geq 1$
 106 unmasked real tokens together with $L \geq 1$ RSP tokens, all attention logits finite. Write the attention
 107 weights as $\alpha_{ij}^{(\ell)}$ and the value vectors on the real and RSP sides as $\mathbf{v}_j^{(\ell)}, \mathbf{v}_{r,j}^{(\ell)}$. Defining the total
 108 attention mass on random tokens $w_{r,i}^{(\ell)} := \sum_{j=1}^L \alpha_{i,n+j}^{(\ell)}$, the real-token mass $1 - w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}$ is positive
 109 and the head output $\mathbf{o}_i^{(\ell)}$ splits *exactly* into a renormalized real-token term $\tilde{\mathbf{o}}_i^{(\ell)}$ and an RSP-induced
 110 contribution $\boldsymbol{\eta}_i^{(\ell)}$:

$$\mathbf{o}_i^{(\ell)} = (1 - w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}) \tilde{\mathbf{o}}_i^{(\ell)} + \boldsymbol{\eta}_i^{(\ell)}, \quad \tilde{\mathbf{o}}_i^{(\ell)} := \sum_{j=1}^n \frac{\alpha_{ij}^{(\ell)}}{1 - w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}} \mathbf{v}_j^{(\ell)}, \quad \boldsymbol{\eta}_i^{(\ell)} := \sum_{j=1}^L \alpha_{i,n+j}^{(\ell)} \mathbf{v}_{r,j}^{(\ell)}. \quad (2)$$

¹ Italic h_j : RSP input space; bold $\mathbf{s}^{(t)}$: hidden state. K denotes the cardinality in top- K analyses; nucleus sampling uses a separate threshold p . t for decoding step, ℓ for self-attention layer.

111 *Derivation of Eq. (2).* Write the head output as $\sum_{j=1}^n \alpha_{ij}^{(\ell)} \mathbf{v}_j^{(\ell)} + \sum_{j=1}^L \alpha_{i,n+j}^{(\ell)} \mathbf{v}_{r_j}^{(\ell)}$, then factor
 112 $1 - w_{r,i}^{(\ell)} = \sum_{j=1}^n \alpha_{ij}^{(\ell)} > 0$ out of the real-token sum. No approximation beyond the softmax-
 113 normalization identity is used. $\square$

114 This single quantity $w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}$ controls both the attenuation ratio $1 - w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}$ on the real signal and the upper
 115 bound on the random contribution $\|\boldsymbol{\eta}_i^{(\ell)}\| \leq w_{r,i}^{(\ell)} \max_j \|\mathbf{v}_{r_j}^{(\ell)}\|$. The *magnitude* of RSP-induced
 116 variation thus reduces to one number in $[0, 1]$. Early in decoding the KV cache is short and this value
 117 is non-negligible, so a single RSP draw can perturb next-token decisions.

118 The scalar w controls *how much*; *where* is decided by the distribution of $\mathbf{H}$. For the local logit
 119 argument, isolate one RSP position and let $\bar{h} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ denote the i.i.d. marginal of any centered vector
 120 $\bar{h}_j$ in Eq. (1), with the other centered RSP positions fixed at zero. Let $z_a(\bar{h})$ be the under-RSP output
 121 logit at vocab token a and write the vocab-logit gap $\Delta_{ab}(\bar{h}) := z_a(\bar{h}) - z_b(\bar{h})$ ($\bar{h} = 0$ is the centered
 122 mean, not the no-RSP state; Appendix C). The transformer’s logit map is non-linear in $\bar{h}$, but a
 123 first-order Taylor expansion around $\bar{h} = 0$ gives the local surrogate $\Delta_{ab}(\bar{h}) \approx \Delta_{ab}(0) + b_{ab}^\top \bar{h}$, with
 124 $b_{ab} := \nabla_{\bar{h}}(z_a - z_b)|_{\bar{h}=0} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ the gradient direction along which vocab tokens a, b swap rank (not
 125 unit-norm in general). Because RSP is training-free, we cannot know in advance which b_{ab} opens
 126 a useful branch, so the distribution must avoid systematically under-perturbing any direction. A
 127 deterministic injection pins to one direction; vocabulary sampling inherits the embedding table’s
 128 anisotropy. The remaining design — maximize the worst-case directional variance at fixed budget —
 129 is uniquely solved by isotropy.

130 **Proposition 1** (Maximin directional coverage). *Let $\mathcal{D}_\rho$ denote the family of zero-mean distributions*
 131 *on $\mathbb{R}^d$ whose covariance satisfies $\text{tr}(\Sigma_D) \leq \rho^2$. For each $D \in \mathcal{D}_\rho$, $\min_{\|b\|=1} \text{Var}_{h \sim D}(b^\top h) =$*
 132 *$\lambda_{\min}(\Sigma_D)$, and $\sup_{D \in \mathcal{D}_\rho} \lambda_{\min}(\Sigma_D) = \rho^2/d$, attained iff $\Sigma_D = (\rho^2/d)\mathbf{I}_d$.*

133 This is a *design criterion* for the prompt law, not a guarantee of correctness; correctness enters
 134 through the task-side $p_{\min}(x)$ assumption of §3.3 and independent resampling.²

135 Gaussian RSP attains the equality with $\Sigma = \sigma_E^2 \mathbf{I}_d$ ($\rho^2 = d\sigma_E^2$) and adds *full support* on $\mathbb{R}^d$
 136 (Appendix C). Isotropy excludes no direction; full support gives positive probability to the open
 137 branching-event region (§3.1) whenever it is non-empty (Appendix D.3.3). Monotone temperature
 138 preserves ranking and cannot reach this region, so RSP’s *rank-changing* branching follows from the
 139 two properties together, splitting the hidden state into multiple branching states early in reasoning.

140 3.3 Annealing: KV cache growth dilutes RSP attention

141 The early branching stabilizes as decoding proceeds: the upper bound on $w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}$ narrows along the
 142 sequence axis with autoregressive cache growth. Each step adds one real-token term while RSP terms
 143 stay fixed; at frozen attention-logit gap, this asymmetry yields the following bound.

144 **Theorem 1** (Attention-mass decay under KV cache growth). *Consider a single attention head with*
 145 *per-head key dimension d_{head} , where query $\mathbf{q}_i$ at position i attends $n \geq 1$ real keys $\mathbf{k}_j$ and $L \geq 1$*
 146 *RSP keys $\mathbf{k}_{r_{j'}}$ under finite logits. Define the pre-scale attention-logit gap $\Delta_i := \min_{j \in [n]} \mathbf{q}_i^\top \mathbf{k}_j -$*
 147 *$\max_{j' \in [L]} \mathbf{q}_i^\top \mathbf{k}_{r_{j'}}$ (distinct from the vocab-logit gap Δ_{ij} of §3.2). In scaled dot-product attention,*

$$w_{r,i} \leq \frac{L}{L + n \exp(\Delta_i / \sqrt{d_{\text{head}}})},$$

148 *and the right-hand side is strictly decreasing in n and tends to 0 at fixed L and Δ_i .*

149 *Proof.* Let $s_j := \mathbf{q}_i^\top \mathbf{k}_j / \sqrt{d_{\text{head}}}$, $s_{r_{j'}} := \mathbf{q}_i^\top \mathbf{k}_{r_{j'}} / \sqrt{d_{\text{head}}}$, $s_{r,\max} := \max_{j'} s_{r_{j'}}$, and $R :=$
 150 $\sum_{j'=1}^L \exp(s_{r_{j'}})$. The gap definition gives $s_j \geq \Delta_i / \sqrt{d_{\text{head}}} + s_{r,\max}$ for every real j , and
 151 $\exp(s_{r,\max}) \geq R/L$ holds because the max dominates the average; combining the two and sum-
 152 ming over the n real keys yields $\sum_{j=1}^n \exp(s_j) \geq (n/L) \exp(\Delta_i / \sqrt{d_{\text{head}}}) R$. Substituting into

²The maximin is stated in input space; isotropy is not claimed to survive transformer layers. Any logit direction pulls back via the model Jacobian to an input-space b , and isotropy guarantees only that no such pulled-back direction has zero projected variance.

153 $w_{r,i} = R/(\sum_j \exp(s_j) + R)$ gives

$$w_{r,i} \leq \frac{R}{(n/L) \exp(\Delta_i/\sqrt{d_{\text{head}}}) R + R} = \frac{L}{L + n \exp(\Delta_i/\sqrt{d_{\text{head}}})}.$$

154 The derivative of the right-hand side in n is $-L \exp(\Delta_i/\sqrt{d_{\text{head}}})/(L + n \exp(\Delta_i/\sqrt{d_{\text{head}}}))^2 < 0$, so
 155 the bound is strictly decreasing and tends to 0 as $n \rightarrow \infty$. $\square$

156 Applied at each layer ℓ to $w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}$ with gap $\Delta_i^{(\ell)}$, L caps the maximum influence while n grows each
 157 step. The theorem guarantees only sequence-axis attenuation at fixed (layer, query, gap); the gap may
 158 sharpen at deeper layers, as suggested empirically by Figure 2, but that effect is outside the theorem’s
 159 scope. The accurate reading is “the attainable upper bound at a fixed gap decreases monotonically.”
 160 Because Eq. (2) ties the random contribution to the same scalar, branching-event reachability inherits
 161 this envelope — as the cache grows, events become rare and the response commits to the branch
 162 already opened, an implicit explore-then-exploit. Figure 2 visualizes this pattern along both axes.

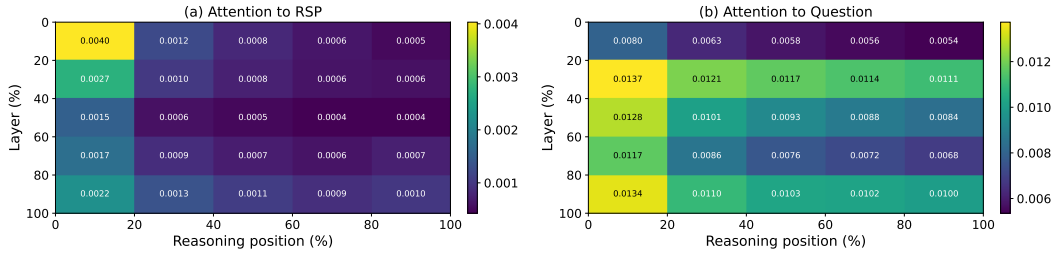


Figure 2: Per-token attention mass on Qwen2.5-Math-7B (*suffix*, 500 MATH-500 problems, independent RSP per problem). (a) RSP-token attention decreases along the reasoning-position axis, matching Theorem 1’s KV cache-growth bound; the additional layer-axis decrease is an empirical phenomenon (deeper layers sharpen the real-vs-random gap) outside Theorem 1’s scope. (b) Question-token attention stays comparatively uniform. Reported quantity: per-token mass of Appendix E, equal to $w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}/L$ averaged over heads and samples.

163 Lifting single-shot branching to task accuracy across N rollouts requires (M1) $p_{\min}(x) > 0$ that
 164 one execution reaches a correct trajectory and (M2) the N executions are mutually independent.
 165 Under both, $\Pr(\text{Pass}@N \text{ on } x) \geq 1 - (1 - p_{\min}(x))^N$ (Appendix D.3.4). §3.2’s isotropy and full
 166 support make local branch opening reachable when the open region is nonempty, but they do not
 167 by themselves guarantee the task-side correctness condition (M1); *independent resampling* supplies
 168 (M2). Sharing one RSP breaks (M2) and removes the accumulation — a signature §4 verifies
 169 empirically.

170 4 Empirical Validation

171 The mechanism of §3 runs from early *branching* through KV cache-growth narrowing to $\text{Pass}@N$
 172 accumulation under independent resampling. We verify this flow across three scenes. First, §4.2 tests
 173 whether RSPs preserve baseline accuracy and even recover it in some settings. Next, §4.3 examines
 174 whether the predicted early diversification and later stabilization appear in entropy and attention
 175 signals. Finally, §4.4 asks whether the $\text{Pass}@N$ gain depends on *independence* of the RSP draw.

176 4.1 Experimental Setup

177 We evaluate on three mathematical reasoning benchmarks, MATH-500 [Lightman et al., 2024],
 178 GSM8K [Cobbe et al., 2021], and AIME24, using LLaMA-3.1-8B-Instruct [Grattafiori et al., 2024]
 179 and the Qwen2.5-Math model family [Yang et al., 2024] across instruct models, base models, and
 180 base models with mismatched chat templates. All experiments use greedy decoding to isolate the
 181 effect of RSPs from sampling stochasticity. RSPs follow the definition of §3.1, using the default *suffix*
 182 position with a freshly drawn $\mathbf{H}$ per batch. Since Theorem 1 identifies the RSP length L as the design
 183 parameter capping the maximum perturbation influence, we ablate $L \in \{10, 15, 20\}$ per model to
 184 identify an appropriate perturbation strength. Tables 1 and 2 report results at the per-model selected

Table 1: Accuracy (%) across model configurations and benchmarks. Values in parentheses indicate the difference from the baseline. Full per-position breakdown is in Appendix A.

Model	MATH-500			GSM8K			AIME24		
	Baseline	RSP(prefix)	RSP(suffix)	Baseline	RSP(prefix)	RSP(suffix)	Baseline	RSP(prefix)	RSP(suffix)
<i>Instruct Models</i>									
LLaMA-3.1-8B-Inst	52.20	45.00 (−7.2)	49.40 (−2.8)	85.75	76.35 (−9.4)	86.73 (+1.0)	6.67	3.33 (−3.3)	10.00 (+3.3)
Qwen2.5-Math-7B-Inst	83.20	81.40 (−1.8)	83.40 (+0.2)	95.45	94.92 (−0.5)	95.68 (+0.2)	13.33	13.33 (+0.0)	16.67 (+3.3)
Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B-Inst	73.00	74.80 (+1.8)	74.20 (+1.2)	85.29	85.29 (+0.0)	84.69 (−0.6)	10.00	13.33 (+3.3)	20.00 (+10.0)
<i>Base Models (Raw Text)</i>									
Qwen2.5-Math-7B	72.20	71.60 (−0.6)	55.60 (−16.6)	84.15	84.31 (+0.2)	54.13 (−30.0)	6.67	16.67 (+10.0)	13.33 (+6.7)
Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B	61.40	64.40 (+3.0)	54.60 (−6.8)	77.86	74.30 (−3.6)	58.61 (−19.3)	16.67	10.00 (−6.7)	3.33 (−13.3)
<i>Base Models + ChatML (Format Mismatch)</i>									
Qwen2.5-Math-7B	52.20	59.20 (+7.0)	70.40 (+18.2)	58.30	56.41 (−1.9)	75.97 (+17.7)	23.33	3.33 (−20.0)	23.33 (+0.0)
Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B	34.40	63.40 (+29.0)	51.00 (+16.6)	37.45	67.02 (+29.6)	50.64 (+13.2)	13.33	20.00 (+6.7)	13.33 (+0.0)

length. The mechanism analyses in §4.3–§4.4 use a fixed setting ($L=10$, *suffix*), which insulates them from this selection effect. Full experimental details and per-position results are in Appendix A.

4.2 How Does Untrained RSP Compare to Baselines & Optimized Soft Prompts?

We first examine how injecting random embeddings affects reasoning performance. Table 1 reports accuracy at the default *suffix* position alongside *prefix* as a position ablation.

On instruct models RSP stays within a few percentage points of the baseline. The most striking pattern is format-mismatch recovery: when a ChatML template is applied to a base model not trained for that format, *Suffix* recovers +18.2/ +17.7 pp on Qwen2.5-Math-7B (MATH-500/GSM8K) and *prefix* recovers up to +29.0/ +29.6 pp on Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B — if simple noise were responsible, accuracy should have dropped further. In the base raw-text setting the picture inverts: *suffix* incurs sharp losses (−16.6/ −30.0 pp on Qwen2.5-Math-7B) while *prefix* changes accuracy less, suggesting base models treat EOS-adjacent signals as a derailment trigger that *prefix* avoids.

RSP’s *direct accuracy gains* concentrate in misaligned-input recovery and stay within $\pm$ a few percentage points on well-aligned instruct models. The effects this paper centers on are the token-, trajectory-, and outcome-level diversity in §4.4, with accuracy recovery as a secondary outcome.

Table 2: Comparison with prior *soft prompt* methods (TTSV, SoftCoT, LTPO) under unified evaluation. Baseline and RSP values are from Table 1. **Bold** denotes the best result and underline denotes the second best for each model–benchmark pair.

Model	Benchmark	Baseline	RSP	TTSV	SoftCoT	LTPO
Qwen2.5-Math-7B-Instruct	MATH-500	83.20	84.20	83.80	82.80	83.00
	GSM8K	<u>95.45</u>	95.68	<u>95.30</u>	95.00	94.84
	AIME24	13.33	<u>16.67</u>	23.30	<u>16.67</u>	13.33
Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B-Instruct	MATH-500	73.00	<u>75.20</u>	<u>75.20</u>	76.00	72.40
	GSM8K	85.29	85.75	<u>85.70</u>	84.46	84.53
	AIME24	<u>10.00</u>	20.00	6.70	6.67	<u>10.00</u>

We further compare RSP with TTSV, SoftCoT, and LTPO — prior *soft prompt* methods that optimize embeddings under different objectives. Table 2 reports a unified evaluation under the same fallback-based answer-extraction pipeline (Appendix A.2). RSP does not consistently dominate the trained methods — TTSV, for instance, beats RSP on AIME24 with Qwen2.5-Math-7B-Instruct (23.30% vs 16.67%). What we want to highlight is precisely the converse claim: even without training, RSP reaches a comparable range, and that fact is itself this paper’s main evidence that part of the *soft-prompt* effect comes from the *structure of injection* rather than the learned content.

4.3 How Does RSP Affect the Output Distribution?

We next examine how RSP injection reshapes the output distribution. The setting is Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B-Instruct on MATH-500, and we measure per-token entropy, top-1 probability, and varentropy

across generation steps. Figure 3 compares these metrics for the first 5% of generation steps across RSP variants and prior *soft prompt* methods (LTPO, SoftCoT, TTSV); full curves are in Appendix A.4.

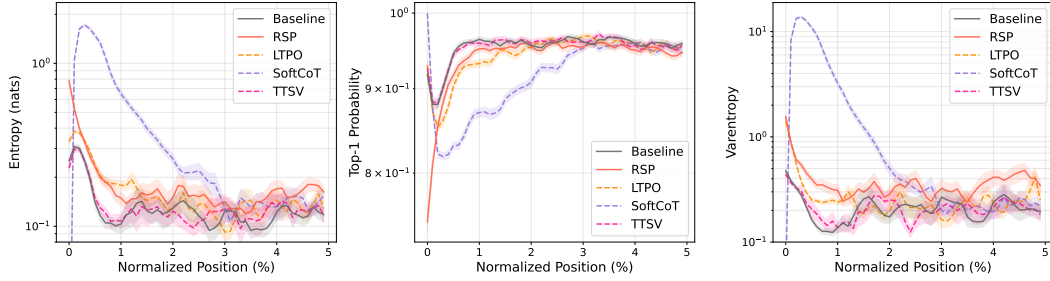


Figure 3: Mean entropy, top-1 probability, and varentropy during the first 5% of generation steps (Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B-Instruct, MATH-500). Shading indicates ± 1 SEM. Solid lines: RSP variants and the baseline. Dashed lines: prior *soft prompt* methods (LTPO, SoftCoT, TTSV).

Latent prompt methods including RSP share the same signature: *a rise in early-generation entropy followed by convergence to the baseline later in generation*. A natural mechanistic explanation is the out-of-vocabulary (OOV) effect — when continuous embeddings outside the vocabulary enter the input, the model has to attend to a never-before-seen key position on top of its familiar token distribution, redistributing probability mass across multiple candidates within the early next-token distribution. All three RSP injection positions show early-stage entropy $\uparrow$, top-1 probability $\downarrow$, and varentropy $\uparrow$, jointly consistent with multimodal distributions [Ahmed et al., 2026]. The change is confined to the early stage and all three metrics return to baseline in the middle and final portions, consistent with the *early influence with automatic KV cache-growth decay* pattern predicted in §3.3.

Prior methods trained under different objectives (LTPO, SoftCoT, TTSV) share this signature. Even TTSV, whose reward explicitly *lowers* mean reasoning-trajectory entropy, shows early-stage entropy comparable to the baseline. The entropy value itself is not a quality score — higher entropy is not always better; rather, the signature reveals a *shared mechanism* in which OOV embedding injection produces the same fingerprint independently of the optimization objective, supporting the hypothesis that the key driver of latent reasoning is the *act of injection*, not the learned content.

4.4 Does RSP Induce Trajectory Diversity?

Section 4.3 empirically established that RSP reshapes the early-stage output distribution. We now examine whether this shift translates into reasoning diversity at three complementary levels of analysis: token rankings, semantic content of trajectories, and task-level outcomes. The three analyses converge on a directional picture: RSP’s first-token perturbation propagates into semantically more diverse reasoning trajectories, which in turn yields greater output diversity at the task level. All three analyses share the setting: Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B-Instruct, MATH-500, *suffix* injection, and $L = 10$.

Token-level: distribution beyond temperature. We quantify how much RSP shifts the first-token distribution — the critical forking point for reasoning trajectories [Wang et al., 2025]. Using the baseline at $\tau=1.0$ as reference, we compare baselines at $\tau=2.0, 3.0$ (16 samples per problem) against RSP at $\tau=1.0$ (averaged over 16 seeds) on three metrics: Spearman rank correlation ρ to detect rank reorganization, the probability mass placed outside the baseline’s top-10 to measure support expansion, and Jensen–Shannon divergence to quantify the overall magnitude of distributional change (formal definitions in Appendix B). Table 3 shows the contrast: RSP’s distributional shift falls between $\tau=2.0$ and $\tau=3.0$ in magnitude, but the mechanism differs — temperature is a monotone transform that preserves ranking ($\rho = 1$ at any τ), while RSP partially preserves but reranks ($\rho = 0.709$). The

Table 3: First-token distribution metrics measured against the baseline at $\tau=1.0$, comparing baselines at higher temperatures ($\tau=2.0, 3.0$) with RSP at $\tau=1.0$. RSP metrics are averaged over 16 random seeds; Acc reports mean $\pm$ std across 16 samples per problem.

Metric	$\tau=2.0$	$\tau=3.0$	RSP
Spearman ρ	1.000	1.000	0.709
Mass outside top-10	5.18%	29.11%	21.86%
JS divergence	0.060	0.218	0.131
Acc (%)	20.77 ± 1.47	1.42 ± 0.35	73.30 ± 1.07

Pass@1 row exposes the cost: matching RSP’s magnitude with temperature toward $\tau=3.0$ collapses accuracy to 1.42%, whereas RSP preserves 73.30%. Thus, RSP produces a fundamentally different perturbation than temperature scaling. Moreover, RSP’s accuracy variability across 16 seeds at $\tau=1.0$ is ± 1.07 , comparable to the ± 1.47 that temperature sampling produces across 16 samples at $\tau=2.0$.

Trajectory-level: semantic diversity. Token-level reranking raises a second question: do first-token perturbations diverge into distinct trajectories, or converge to similar ones? We sample 64 problems from MATH-500 and generate 300 independent trajectories per problem under Baseline and RSP at $\tau = 1.0$. Each trajectory is encoded by BGE-M3 [Chen et al., 2024] into a dense semantic vector, and we compute three metrics: *pairwise cosine distance* (overall semantic spread), *inter-cluster distance* between centroids of DBSCAN [Ester et al., 1996], a density-based clustering algorithm (separation between distinct trajectory groups), and *intra-cluster distance* (coherence within groups). Table 4 reveals three concurrent patterns: pairwise distance rises by $1.4\times$, inter-cluster distance jumps by $5.4\times$, and intra-cluster distance is essentially unchanged — the trajectory set becomes more diverse and splits into more separated groups while preserving within-group coherence. RSP also yields larger pairwise distance than baseline on 56 of 64 problems.

Table 4: Semantic diversity metrics (64 problems, 300 trajectories per condition).

Metric	Baseline	RSP
Pairwise cos. dist.	0.0612	0.0879
Inter-cluster dist.	0.0183	0.0982
Intra-cluster dist.	0.0526	0.0528

Outcome-level: Pass@N scaling. Does this token- and trajectory-level diversity translate into task-level outcome diversity, measured by Pass@N [Chen et al., 2021] (the probability that at least one of N sampled solutions is correct)? We generate 16 samples per problem on MATH-500 and AIME24 and compare four conditions: (i) *Baseline* at $\tau = 1.0$; (ii) *RSP (single seed)* at $\tau = 1.0$, with one RSP shared across all samples; (iii) *RSP (indep. seed)* with greedy decoding, a fresh RSP per sample; and (iv) *RSP (indep. seed)* at $\tau = 1.0$, a fresh RSP per sample.

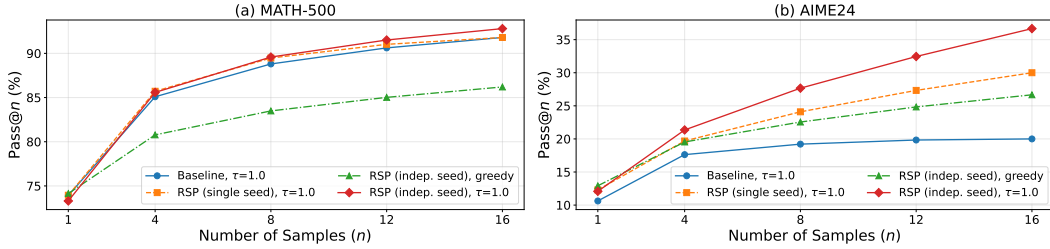


Figure 4: Pass@N scaling on (a) MATH-500 and (b) AIME24 with Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B-Instruct, 16 samples per problem. *Baseline*: temperature sampling only. *RSP (single seed)*: single RSP shared across samples combined with temperature. *RSP (indep. seed)*: a different RSP per sample, with or without temperature.

Condition (iv) achieves the highest Pass@N on both benchmarks, reaching 92.80% on MATH-500 and 36.67% on AIME24 at $N = 16$, while (ii) shows no improvement over the baseline — the diversity gain depends on varying the embeddings across samples rather than fixing a single perturbation. Pass@1 stays comparable to the baseline on MATH-500, and on the harder AIME24 (iv) even surpasses it, suggesting that independent RSPs combined with temperature sampling expand trajectory diversity without sacrificing single-sample accuracy.

5 Application: DAPO Training with RSP

Sections 3–4 established what RSP does (attention-mediated branch opening) and how it behaves at inference (Pass@N gains, rank-changing diversity unattainable by temperature). Can we use the same effect at training time? Rollout diversity drives learning in sampling-based RL, and DAPO [Yu et al., 2025] is a recent GRPO [Shao et al., 2024] variant explicitly designed to preserve diversity at the loss level. We use it as a stringent testbed: does input-side branch opening compose with loss-side preservation to yield further gains? Details and per-step results are in Appendix F.

DAPO preserves rollout diversity at the loss level by reshaping how rollouts are weighted and clipped during long chain-of-thought RL; RSP induces diversity *before* the loss is computed by

289 perturbing the rollout distribution at the input level (§4.4). Writing each rollout’s token sequence as
 290 $y_i = (y_{i,1}, \dots, y_{i,|y_i|})$ (using y to avoid collision with the head output $\mathbf{o}_i^{(\ell)}$ of §3.2) and pairing each
 291 rollout with an independently sampled RSP $\mathbf{H}_i$ (reused at update time to keep the update on-policy),
 292 importance ratio $r_{i,t}(\theta) = \pi_\theta(y_{i,t} | q, \mathbf{H}_i, y_{i,<t}) / \pi_{\theta_{\text{old}}}(y_{i,t} | q, \mathbf{H}_i, y_{i,<t})$, group-relative advantage
 293 $\hat{A}_{i,t}$, and asymmetric clip range $(\varepsilon_{\text{low}}, \varepsilon_{\text{high}})$, the DAPO + RSP objective is

$$\mathcal{J}_{\text{DAPO+RSP}}(\theta) = \mathbb{E} \left[\frac{1}{\sum_i |y_i|} \sum_{i,t} \min(r_{i,t} \hat{A}_{i,t}, \text{clip}(r_{i,t}, 1-\varepsilon_{\text{low}}, 1+\varepsilon_{\text{high}}) \hat{A}_{i,t}) \right]. \quad (3)$$

Table 5: Per-benchmark accuracy (%) at each method’s peak step on Qwen2.5-Math-7B. **Bold** denotes the better of the two RL methods on each benchmark. Avg is the unweighted five-benchmark mean.

Method	GSM8K	MATH-500	College	Minerva	AIME 24	Avg
Base	57.2	52.6	18.3	13.6	8.6	30.06
DAPO	86.3	78.2	41.4	37.5	22.6	53.20
DAPO + RSP	87.7	78.6	42.2	39.7	23.6	54.36

294 We train Qwen2.5-Math-7B on a MATH Level-3–5 subset (~8.5K prompts) with SimpleRL-Zoo
 295 [Zeng et al., 2025] under Eq. (3): each step uses $G = 8$ rollouts per prompt at $\tau=1.0$, batch 1,024,
 296 4 PPO mini-batches of 256, for 100 steps. *DAPO* is compared against *DAPO + RSP*, where *suffix*
 297 *RSP* ($L=20$) is applied during rollouts only and evaluation uses no RSP. We evaluate on five math
 298 benchmarks (GSM8K [Cobbe et al., 2021], MATH-500 [Lightman et al., 2024], College Math,
 299 Minerva Math [Lewkowycz et al., 2022], AIME 2024) and report the unweighted mean; AIME 2024
 300 uses Avg@32 at $\tau=1.0$, the others greedy.

301 Figure 5 and Table 5 show two patterns: a late-
 302 stage advantage and a delayed early reward growth.
 303 DAPO + RSP reaches 54.36% at step 90 (vs DAPO’s
 304 53.20% peak, +1.16 pp) and widens the gap to +3.10 pp
 305 at step 100 with DAPO’s post-peak decline delayed;
 306 earlier the curves cross around step 20. The patterns follow
 307 from the methods acting at separate stages: DAPO pre-
 308 serves diversity at the loss level over already-generated
 309 rollouts while RSP perturbs the hidden states that pro-
 310 duce them (§3.2), exposing the policy to broader learn-
 311 ing signals. This is the exploration–exploitation dy-
 312 namics of RL [Sutton and Barto, 2018] induced from
 313 the input. These results use a single training seed and
 314 should be read as a feasibility demonstration; multi-seed
 315 evaluation is future work.

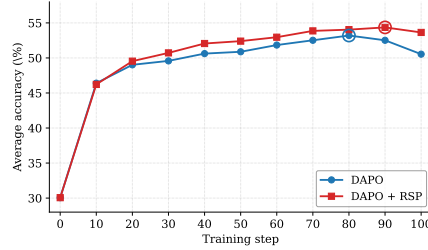


Figure 5: Five-benchmark average accuracy on Qwen2.5-Math-7B. DAPO + RSP reaches a higher peak (step 90) and stays stable through step 100.

316 6 Conclusion

317 We studied Random Soft Prompts (RSPs), training-free isotropic Gaussian vectors fitted to pretrained
 318 embedding statistics. The magnitude of the RSP contribution per attention layer is controlled by the
 319 scalar $w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}$, whose fixed-gap upper bound shrinks under KV cache growth, and isotropic resampling
 320 reaches top- K entry regions that rank-preserving temperature cannot (§3). Latent-prompt methods
 321 share the same entropy signature, the gain vanishes when one RSP is shared across samples (§4),
 322 and DAPO + RSP yields a modest late-training advantage (§5). This signature emerges from purely
 323 random input-side perturbation, suggesting that part of what trained *soft prompts* have been credited
 324 with is a *structural by-product of injection*, and that RSP composes orthogonally with sampling-based
 325 pipelines as a near-zero-cost diversity expander. Open questions remain on generalization beyond
 326 RoPE decoders and math reasoning, deep-layer sharpening outside Theorem 1’s envelope, multi-seed
 327 DAPO variance, and held-out hyperparameter selection (§4.1).

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A Experimental Setup and Full Accuracy Breakdown

All experiments are conducted on a single NVIDIA A6000 40GB GPU with greedy decoding, a maximum generation length of 3,072 tokens for MATH-500 and GSM8K, and 4,096 tokens for AIME24. Batch size is fixed per model (16 for LLaMA-3.1-8B-Instruct and Qwen2.5-Math-7B variants, 32 for Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B variants). The RSP token count L is selected per (model, benchmark) pair from $\{10, 15, 20\}$ (Table 7); the per-position breakdown is in Table 6.

Table 6: Accuracy (%) across model configurations, injection positions, and benchmarks. Values in parentheses indicate the difference from the baseline. **Bold** denotes the best result and underline denotes the second best for each model–benchmark pair.

Model	Mode	MATH-500	GSM8K	AIME24
<i>Instruct Models</i>				
LLaMA-3.1-8B-Instruct	Baseline	52.20	85.75	<u>6.67</u>
	Prefix	45.00 (−7.2)	76.35 (−9.4)	3.33 (−3.3)
	Suffix	<u>49.40</u> (−2.8)	86.73 (+1.0)	10.00 (+3.3)
Qwen2.5-Math-7B-Instruct	Baseline	83.20	95.45	<u>13.33</u>
	Prefix	81.40 (−1.8)	94.92 (−0.5)	<u>13.33</u> (+0.0)
	Suffix	83.40 (+0.2)	95.68 (+0.2)	16.67 (+3.3)
Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B-Instruct	Baseline	73.00	<u>85.29</u>	10.00
	Prefix	74.80 (+1.8)	85.29 (+0.0)	<u>13.33</u> (+3.3)
	Suffix	74.20 (+1.2)	84.69 (−0.6)	20.00 (+10.0)
<i>Base Models (Raw Text)</i>				
Qwen2.5-Math-7B	Baseline	72.20	84.15	6.67
	Prefix	<u>71.60</u> (−0.6)	84.31 (+0.2)	16.67 (+10.0)
	Suffix	55.60 (−16.6)	54.13 (−30.0)	<u>13.33</u> (+6.7)
Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B	Baseline	<u>61.40</u>	77.86	16.67
	Prefix	64.40 (+3.0)	<u>74.30</u> (−3.6)	<u>10.00</u> (−6.7)
	Suffix	54.60 (−6.8)	58.61 (−19.3)	3.33 (−13.3)
<i>Base Models + ChatML (Format Mismatch)</i>				
Qwen2.5-Math-7B	Baseline	52.20	58.30	23.33
	Prefix	59.20 (+7.0)	56.41 (−1.9)	<u>3.33</u> (−20.0)
	Suffix	70.40 (+18.2)	75.97 (+17.7)	23.33 (+0.0)
Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B	Baseline	34.40	37.45	<u>13.33</u>
	Prefix	63.40 (+29.0)	67.02 (+29.6)	20.00 (+6.7)
	Suffix	<u>51.00</u> (+16.6)	<u>50.64</u> (+13.2)	<u>13.33</u> (+0.0)

Table 7: Number of RSP tokens (L) used for each model and benchmark.

Model	MATH-500	GSM8K	AIME24
LLaMA-3.1-8B-Instruct	15	20	15
Qwen2.5-Math-7B-Instruct	20	20	20
Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B-Instruct	20	10	20
Qwen2.5-Math-7B	10	10	20
Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B	10	10	20
Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B (ChatML)	20	20	10
Qwen2.5-Math-7B (ChatML)	20	20	20

A.1 RSP Injection Positions and Prompt Templates

Below we show the prompt structure for each injection position across all model types. **Blue text** indicates RSP embeddings, and **purple text** indicates special tokens.

A.1.1 Prefix

RSP embeddings are concatenated before the prompt embeddings. No text modification is applied.

ChatML (Qwen Instruct / Base + ChatML).


```
[Random Embeddings ( $L$  tokens)]
<|im_start|>system
Please reason step by step, and put your final answer within \boxed{<|im_end|>
<|im_start|>user
{question}<|im_end|>
<|im_start|>assistant
```

LLaMA Chat Template.

```
[Random Embeddings ( $L$  tokens)]
<|begin_of_text|>
<|start_header_id|>system<|end_header_id|>
Cutting Knowledge Date: December 2023
Today Date: 26 Jul 2024
Please reason step by step, and put your final answer within \boxed{<|eot_id|>
<|start_header_id|>user<|end_header_id|>
{question}<|eot_id|>
<|start_header_id|>assistant<|end_header_id|>
```

Raw Text (Qwen Base).

```
[Random Embeddings ( $L$  tokens)]
{question}
Please reason step by step, and put your final answer within \boxed{<|eot_id|>
```

A.1.2 Infix

A description text and special tokens are inserted into the prompt. The special token positions are then replaced with RSP embeddings at the embedding level.

ChatML (Qwen Instruct / Base + ChatML).

```
<|im_start|>system
Please reason step by step, and put your final answer within \boxed{<|im_end|>
<|im_start|>user
{question}

There are { $L$ } special tokens that contain compressed latent reasoning information that
might be useful for your reasoning. If these tokens are useful for your case, you can
use them as reference. If these tokens are not useful for your case, you can ignore
them and focus back to solving the problem.

Here are the { $L$ } special tokens: <special_token_1>...<special_token_ $L$ >
<|im_end|>
<|im_start|>assistant
```

LLaMA Chat Template.

```
<|begin_of_text|>
<|start_header_id|>system<|end_header_id|>
Cutting Knowledge Date: December 2023
Today Date: 26 Jul 2024
Please reason step by step, and put your final answer within \boxed{<|eot_id|>
<|start_header_id|>user<|end_header_id|>
{question}

There are { $L$ } special tokens that contain compressed latent reasoning information that
might be useful for your reasoning. If these tokens are useful for your case, you can
use them as reference. If these tokens are not useful for your case, you can ignore
them and focus back to solving the problem.

Here are the { $L$ } special tokens:
<reserved_special_token_0>...
<reserved_special_token_ $L$ >
<|eot_id|>
<|start_header_id|>assistant<|end_header_id|>
```

547 **Raw Text (Qwen Base).**

```
{question}
There are {L} special tokens that contain compressed latent reasoning information that
might be useful for your reasoning. If these tokens are useful for your case, you can
use them as reference. If these tokens are not useful for your case, you can ignore
them and focus back to solving the problem.

Here are the {L} special tokens: <special_token_1>...<special_token_L>

Please reason step by step, and put your final answer within \boxed{}
```

549 **A.1.3 Suffix**

550 For chat-templated models, RSP embeddings are inserted immediately before the end-of-turn token.
551 For raw text models, RSP embeddings are concatenated at the end of the prompt.

552 **ChatML (Qwen Instruct / Base + ChatML).**

```
<|im_start|>system
Please reason step by step, and put your final answer within \boxed{}.<|im_end|>
<|im_start|>user
{question}[Random Embeddings (L tokens)]<|im_end|>
<|im_start|>assistant
```

554 **LLaMA Chat Template.**

```
<|begin_of_text|>
<|start_header_id|>system<|end_header_id|>
Cutting Knowledge Date: December 2023
Today Date: 26 Jul 2024
Please reason step by step, and put your final answer within \boxed{}.<|eot_id|>
<|start_header_id|>user<|end_header_id|>
{question}[Random Embeddings (L tokens)]<|eot_id|>
<|start_header_id|>assistant<|end_header_id|>
```

556 **Raw Text (Qwen Base).**

```
{question}
Please reason step by step, and put your final answer within \boxed{}. [Random
Embeddings (L tokens)]
```

558 **A.2 Answer Extraction and Grading**

559 The final answer is extracted from the model output through a fallback chain. Each step is attempted
560 in order; if extraction fails, the next step is tried.

Answer Extraction Fallback Chain

1. "final answer is \$...\$. I hope" pattern (Minerva format)
2. \boxed{...}: last non-empty box is used; empty \boxed{} are skipped
3. Text following "the answer is"
4. Text following "final answer is"
5. Last number in the output (regex fallback)

562 Extracted answers are normalized by removing \$, \left, \right, and unit strings. Grading
563 is performed via symbolic equivalence checking: exact string match, numerical comparison
564 (`math.isclose, rel_tol=1e-4`), and SymPy symbolic simplification.

565 **A.3 Reproduced Prior Work Hyperparameters**

566 All prior methods are reproduced on Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B-Instruct and Qwen2.5-Math-7B-Instruct,
567 evaluated with greedy decoding (temperature = 0) and our unified answer extraction pipeline.

568 **TTSV.** *Prefix* length 20, trained for 20 epochs with AdamW optimizer, batch size 2, gradient
569 accumulation 8 steps, and linear learning rate schedule. Learning rate is 1e-3 for Qwen-1.5B and
570 1e-5 for Qwen-7B.

571 **LTPO.** Table 8 reports the per-benchmark hyperparameters.

Table 8: LTPO hyperparameters.

Parameter	GSM8K	MATH-500	AIME24
tokens	8	8	8
steps	20	20	20
top_k	10	10	10
sigma	20	20	5
sigma_decay	0.95	0.95	0.95
lr	1e-2	5e-3	5e-2

572 **SoftCoT.** Projection module trained for 10 epochs. Thought tokens: 32 during training, 4 during
573 evaluation. Batch size 4 for GSM8K, 1 for MATH with gradient accumulation 4. The small (assistant)
574 model is Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B-Instruct in both configurations, while the large model is Qwen2.5-
575 Math-1.5B-Instruct (learning rate 2e-5) or Qwen2.5-Math-7B-Instruct (learning rate 5e-6). For
576 MATH-500 and AIME24 evaluation, we use the projection module trained on GSM8K, as it yields
577 higher accuracy than the one trained on MATH.

578 A.4 Full Entropy Curves

579 Figure 6 shows the full normalized (0–100%) generation trajectories for entropy, top-1 probability,
580 and varentropy, and Table 9 reports the corresponding scalar statistics including overall means,
581 first-5% means, and the average number of generated tokens per problem. All methods converge to
582 similar levels after the initial generation stage, confirming that the distributional changes induced by
583 RSP are localized to the early reasoning phase.

Table 9: Per-step statistics for Qwen2.5-Math-1.5B-Instruct on MATH-500 across the full generation and the first 5% of generation steps, together with the average number of generated tokens per problem. Top-1 Prob (overall) is reported as a weighted average over the first-10%/middle/last-10% segment means with weights 0.1/0.8/0.1. Extension of Figure 3 (main text) and Figure 6.

Metric	Baseline	<i>Prefix</i>	<i>Infix</i>	<i>Suffix</i>	LTPO	SoftCoT	TTSV
Tokens (mean)	575.7	558.4	549.9	573.3	592.3	594.4	577.4
Entropy (first 5%)	0.1332	0.1366	0.1402	0.1941	0.1662	0.4218	0.1359
Entropy (overall)	0.0871	0.0881	0.0899	0.1049	0.0909	0.1059	0.0864
Top-1 Prob (first 5%)	0.9535	0.9523	0.9525	0.9373	0.9437	0.9156	0.9534
Top-1 Prob (overall)	0.9684	0.9681	0.9678	0.9647	0.9683	0.9651	0.9685
Varentropy (first 5%)	0.2181	0.2207	0.2463	0.4010	0.2953	2.2234	0.2174
Varentropy (overall)	0.1353	0.1375	0.1422	0.2038	0.1452	0.2404	0.1361

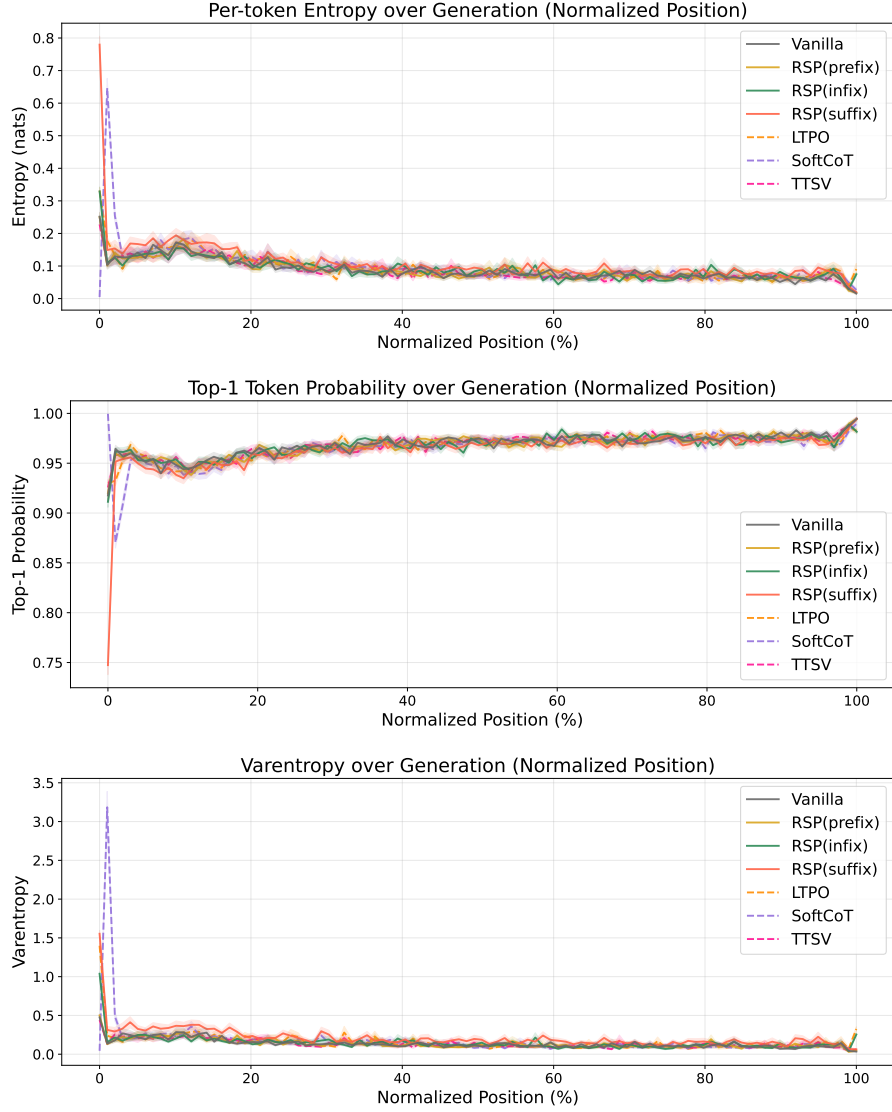


Figure 6: Mean entropy (top), top-1 probability (middle), and varentropy (bottom) over the full normalized generation trajectory (0–100%). Averaged over MATH-500, shading indicates ± 1 SEM. Solid lines: RSP variants and the baseline. Dashed lines: prior *soft prompt* methods. All methods converge after the initial stage.

584 B Token-Level Distribution Metrics

585 This appendix provides formal definitions for the metrics used in Section 4.4. Numerical results
 586 are reported in Table 3 of the main text. We extract first-token logits via a single forward pass (no
 587 autoregressive generation) and store the top-100 token ids and logit values per problem. Temperature
 588 conditions reuse the baseline logits scaled by $1/\tau$, requiring no separate inference. RSP draws
 589 16 independent seeds per problem (MATH-500), and reported metrics are the mean across the 16
 590 seeds. Pass@1 accuracy is computed over 16 samples per problem, with the baseline at $\tau=1.0$
 591 reaching $73.92 \pm 0.78\%$. Let P_{base} denote the baseline next-token distribution at $\tau=1.0$ and P_{target} the
 592 candidate distribution being compared (e.g., baselines at $\tau=2.0, 3.0$ or RSP at $\tau=1.0$). All metrics
 593 are computed analytically from saved logits at the first generation step.

594 **Spearman rank correlation.** Spearman’s ρ is the Pearson correlation coefficient between the token
 595 ranks of two distributions:

$$\rho = \text{Pearson}(\text{rank}(P_{\text{target}}), \text{rank}(P_{\text{base}})). \quad (4)$$

596 Because temperature scaling $P^{(\tau)} \propto P^{1/\tau}$ is a strictly monotone transform, the rank order of tokens
 597 is preserved exactly, so $\rho = 1$ for any $\tau > 0$ as a mathematical identity. Any value $\rho < 1$ therefore
 598 indicates rank reorganization beyond what temperature scaling can produce.

599 **Mass outside top- K .** Let $\text{TopK}(P_{\text{base}})$ be the set of K tokens with the highest probability under
 600 P_{base} . The probability mass that the candidate distribution places *outside* this set is

$$\text{MassOutside}_K = 1 - \sum_{t \in \text{TopK}(P_{\text{base}})} P_{\text{target}}(t). \quad (5)$$

601 This directly measures support expansion: how much probability the candidate assigns to tokens that
 602 are not in the baseline’s preferred set. Reported values use $K = 10$.

603 **Jensen–Shannon divergence.** The symmetrized, bounded version of Kullback–Leibler divergence:

$$\text{JS}(P, Q) = \frac{1}{2} \text{KL}(P \parallel M) + \frac{1}{2} \text{KL}(Q \parallel M), \quad M = \frac{1}{2}(P + Q). \quad (6)$$

604 We use base-2 logarithms so that $\text{JS} \in [0, 1]$. Tokens absent from the stored top-100 are assigned a
 605 sentinel logit (-10^9) before softmax, which is negligible for our setting.

C Prompt-Law Properties Used by the Theory

This appendix isolates the only properties of the RSP law used in the main text: centeredness, direction-agnostic covariance under a variance budget, and positive probability on every nonempty open set. We avoid stronger semantic claims because Section 3.2 needs only these geometric and measure-theoretic facts.

C.1 Centered Perturbations Do Not Impose Systematic First-Order Drift

Let z_i^{Base} denote the no-RSP output logit at vocab token i and $z_i^{\text{RSP}}(\bar{h})$ the corresponding logit when the centered RSP perturbation takes value $\bar{h}$. The (true) vocab-logit gap under RSP is $\Delta_{ij}(\bar{h}) := z_i^{\text{RSP}}(\bar{h}) - z_j^{\text{RSP}}(\bar{h})$, distinct from the no-RSP baseline gap $\Delta_{ij}^{\text{Base}} := z_i^{\text{Base}} - z_j^{\text{Base}}$. Note that $\bar{h} = 0$ corresponds to the centered RSP at its entrywise mean rather than to the no-RSP forward pass, so in general $\Delta_{ij}(0) \neq \Delta_{ij}^{\text{Base}}$. The transformer’s logit map is non-linear in $\bar{h}$, but a first-order Taylor expansion around $\bar{h} = 0$ yields the local surrogate

$$\Delta_{ij}^{\text{lin}}(\bar{h}) := \Delta_{ij} + b_{ij}^\top \bar{h},$$

with $\Delta_{ij} := \Delta_{ij}(0)$ and $b_{ij} := \nabla_{\bar{h}}(z_i^{\text{RSP}} - z_j^{\text{RSP}})|_{\bar{h}=0}$. The proposition below is stated for the surrogate Δ_{ij}^{lin} . For the true non-linear gap $\Delta_{ij}(\bar{h})$, the first-order term has zero mean under centered perturbations, but the Taylor remainder $r_{ij}(\bar{h}) = O(\|\bar{h}\|^2)$ may contribute a second-order mean shift; we make no claim about its sign or magnitude.

Proposition 2 (No systematic first-order drift in the surrogate). *If $\mathbb{E}[\bar{h}] = 0$, then*

$$\mathbb{E}[\Delta_{ij}^{\text{lin}}(\bar{h})] = \Delta_{ij}$$

for every token pair (i, j) . If a deterministic centered prompt $\bar{h}_0$ is reused across runs, then

$$\Delta_{ij}^{\text{lin}}(\bar{h}_0) - \Delta_{ij} = b_{ij}^\top \bar{h}_0$$

is a fixed directional bias.

Proof. The centered case is immediate from linearity of expectation:

$$\mathbb{E}[\Delta_{ij}^{\text{lin}}(\bar{h})] = \Delta_{ij} + b_{ij}^\top \mathbb{E}[\bar{h}] = \Delta_{ij}.$$

The deterministic case follows by substitution. $\square$

This proposition rules out a run-averaged first-order bias. It does not say that individual prompt draws leave the logits unchanged.

C.2 Proof of Proposition 1

For a unit vector b , the first-order perturbation energy available along b is $\text{Var}_{h \sim D}(b^\top h) = b^\top \Sigma_D b$. The worst-case directional energy is therefore the minimum Rayleigh quotient of Σ_D .

Proof. For any symmetric covariance matrix Σ_D ,

$$\min_{\|b\|=1} b^\top \Sigma_D b = \lambda_{\min}(\Sigma_D).$$

Let the eigenvalues of Σ_D be $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_d$. Then

$$\lambda_{\min}(\Sigma_D) \leq \frac{1}{d} \sum_{m=1}^d \lambda_m = \frac{\text{tr}(\Sigma_D)}{d} \leq \frac{\rho^2}{d}.$$

Equality holds if and only if all eigenvalues are equal, i.e., $\Sigma_D = (\rho^2/d)\mathbf{I}_d$. $\square$

The proof uses only covariance. We choose a Gaussian law for RSP because it adds the open-set reachability property proved next.

637 **C.3 Open-Set Reachability of Isotropic Gaussian Prompts**

638 **Proposition 3** (Open-set reachability). *Let $\bar{h} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2 \mathbf{I}_d)$ with $\sigma > 0$. Then every nonempty open*
 639 *set $U \subseteq \mathbb{R}^d$ satisfies*

$$\Pr(\bar{h} \in U) > 0.$$

640 *Proof.* The Gaussian density

$$(2\pi\sigma^2)^{-d/2} \exp\left(-\frac{\|\bar{h}\|^2}{2\sigma^2}\right)$$

641 is strictly positive at every point of $\mathbb{R}^d$. Every nonempty open set contains a ball of positive Lebesgue
 642 measure, and integrating a strictly positive density over that ball gives positive probability. $\square$

643 This is the only support property used in the informal branching argument of §3.2 and in Ap-
 644 pendix D.3.3.

645 D Proofs for the Transformer-Level Mechanism

646 This appendix follows the same order as the main theory section: exploration, annealing, and
647 performance gain. The prompt-law facts used before these proofs are collected in Appendix C.

648 D.1 Exploration: attention decomposition and perturbation size

649 **Proposition 4** (Attention decomposition). *For one attention head at query position i in layer ℓ , let*
650 *$\alpha_{ij}^{(\ell)}$ be the attention weights over $n \geq 1$ unmasked real tokens and $L \geq 1$ random tokens, with finite*
651 *attention logits. Define*

$$w_{r,i}^{(\ell)} := \sum_{j=1}^L \alpha_{i,n+j}^{(\ell)}$$

652 and, for $j \in [n]$,

$$\tilde{\alpha}_{ij}^{(\ell)} := \frac{\alpha_{ij}^{(\ell)}}{1 - w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}}.$$

653 Then

$$\mathbf{o}_i^{(\ell)} = (1 - w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}) \tilde{\mathbf{o}}_i^{(\ell)} + \boldsymbol{\eta}_i^{(\ell)},$$

654 where

$$\tilde{\mathbf{o}}_i^{(\ell)} := \sum_{j=1}^n \tilde{\alpha}_{ij}^{(\ell)} \mathbf{v}_j^{(\ell)} \quad \text{and} \quad \boldsymbol{\eta}_i^{(\ell)} := \sum_{j=1}^L \alpha_{i,n+j}^{(\ell)} \mathbf{v}_{r_j}^{(\ell)}.$$

655 *Proof.* The head output is

$$\mathbf{o}_i^{(\ell)} = \sum_{j=1}^n \alpha_{ij}^{(\ell)} \mathbf{v}_j^{(\ell)} + \sum_{j=1}^L \alpha_{i,n+j}^{(\ell)} \mathbf{v}_{r_j}^{(\ell)}.$$

656 By the softmax positivity and the existence of at least one unmasked real token, $\sum_{j=1}^n \alpha_{ij}^{(\ell)} =$
657 $1 - w_{r,i}^{(\ell)} > 0$, so

$$\sum_{j=1}^n \alpha_{ij}^{(\ell)} \mathbf{v}_j^{(\ell)} = (1 - w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}) \sum_{j=1}^n \frac{\alpha_{ij}^{(\ell)}}{1 - w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}} \mathbf{v}_j^{(\ell)} = (1 - w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}) \tilde{\mathbf{o}}_i^{(\ell)}.$$

658 Substituting this identity gives the decomposition. □

659 **Corollary 1** (Magnitude scales with random-token attention). *For every realization of the random*
660 *values,*

$$\|\boldsymbol{\eta}_i^{(\ell)}\| \leq w_{r,i}^{(\ell)} \max_{j \in [L]} \|\mathbf{v}_{r_j}^{(\ell)}\|.$$

661 *Proof.* By the triangle inequality,

$$\|\boldsymbol{\eta}_i^{(\ell)}\| = \left\| \sum_{j=1}^L \alpha_{i,n+j}^{(\ell)} \mathbf{v}_{r_j}^{(\ell)} \right\| \leq \sum_{j=1}^L \alpha_{i,n+j}^{(\ell)} \|\mathbf{v}_{r_j}^{(\ell)}\| \leq w_{r,i}^{(\ell)} \max_{j \in [L]} \|\mathbf{v}_{r_j}^{(\ell)}\|.$$

662 □

663 Corollary 1 is the only quantitative fact needed in the main text. No independence assumption
664 between attention weights and random keys is required. Once $w_{r,i}^{(\ell)}$ is small, the random contribution
665 must be small as well.

666 D.2 Corollaries of Theorem 1 on KV cache growth

667 The fixed-gap decay bound yields the corollaries below.

668 **Corollary 2** (Sequence-wise annealing of the fixed-gap envelope). *For fixed L and $\Delta_i^{(\ell)}$, the upper*
 669 *bound*

$$f(n) = \frac{L}{L + n \exp(\Delta_i^{(\ell)} / \sqrt{d_{\text{head}}})}$$

670 *is strictly decreasing in n and tends to 0 as $n \rightarrow \infty$. KV cache growth alone therefore narrows the*
 671 *largest RSP attention mass compatible with that gap.*

672 During autoregressive decoding $\Delta_i^{(\ell)}$ also moves because queries, keys, and hidden states co-evolve.
 673 The accurate reading is not “the realized mass decreases at every step” but “the envelope compatible
 674 with a fixed gap shrinks as the KV cache grows.”

675 *Proof.* Differentiate $f(n)$ with respect to n :

$$f'(n) = -\frac{L \exp(\Delta_i^{(\ell)} / \sqrt{d_{\text{head}}})}{\left(L + n \exp(\Delta_i^{(\ell)} / \sqrt{d_{\text{head}}})\right)^2} < 0.$$

676 Thus $f(n)$ is strictly decreasing, and its denominator diverges linearly in n while its numerator is
 677 fixed, so $f(n) \rightarrow 0$. $\square$

678 **Corollary 3** (Vanishing random contribution under annealing). *If $n \rightarrow \infty$ while L and $\Delta_i^{(\ell)}$ remain*
 679 *fixed, $w_{r,i}^{(\ell)} \rightarrow 0$, and for every realization of the random values*

$$\|\boldsymbol{\eta}_i^{(\ell)}\| \leq w_{r,i}^{(\ell)} \max_{j \in [L]} \|\mathbf{v}_{r_j}^{(\ell)}\| \rightarrow 0.$$

680 *Proof.* $w_{r,i}^{(\ell)} \rightarrow 0$ by Corollary 2. Apply Corollary 1 to bound $\|\boldsymbol{\eta}_i^{(\ell)}\|$. The maximum norm is finite
 681 for any realization of finitely many sampled values. $\square$

682 D.3 Performance gain: from local admission to Pass@N

683 From here we work at the vocab-logit and task levels, dropping the per-layer index ℓ . The main text
 684 uses a first-order surrogate to state two claims: the §3.2 claim that a baseline-excluded vocab token
 685 can enter the local top- K set, and the §3.3 closing that independent reruns turn such local openings
 686 into Pass@ N gains. The proofs below use only one support condition on the centered prompt law D :

$$(S1) \quad D(U) > 0 \quad \text{for every nonempty open set } U \subseteq \mathbb{R}^d.$$

687 Proposition 3 shows that the isotropic Gaussian law of §3.2 satisfies (S1).

688 D.3.1 Autoregressive Formulation

689 In autoregressive decoding, the joint distribution over a sequence $y_{1:T}$ factorizes as

$$\Pr(y_{1:T} \mid x) = \prod_{t=1}^T p(y_t \mid x, y_{<t}),$$

690 where each step is governed by a prefix-conditioned distribution. Any perturbation introduced by
 691 RSP affects generation through a sequence of local changes to $p(y_t \mid x, y_{<t})$, rather than a single
 692 global distribution.

693 D.3.2 Local Linearization of Logits under RSP

694 Throughout this subsection, $\bar{h} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ denotes *one* centered prompt vector from the RSP definition
 695 (Eq. (1) in §3.1), treated as a per-token surrogate. The actual implementation uses a length- L prompt
 696 $\mathbf{H} = (h_1, \dots, h_L)$ with L independent draws; the arguments below isolate how one local perturbation
 697 can shift the logits. We model the perturbed logits as a function $z_i(\bar{h})$, assuming local smoothness in
 698 a neighborhood of $\bar{h} = 0$:

$$z_i(\bar{h}) = z_i(0) + \nabla_{\bar{h}} z_i(0)^\top \bar{h} + r_i(\bar{h}),$$

699 where $r_i(\bar{h}) = O(\|\bar{h}\|^2)$. Defining $a_i := \nabla_{\bar{h}} z_i(0)$ and $z_i := z_i(0)$, we obtain the local affine
 700 surrogate

$$z_i^{\text{lin}}(\bar{h}) := z_i + a_i^\top \bar{h}.$$

701 This approximation is used as a first-order surrogate for branch opening, not as an exact global model
 702 of the transformer logits.

703 D.3.3 Top- K entry region (Remark)

704 This complements the informal branching argument in §3.2. Define the entry region

$$\mathcal{G}_{i,K} := \{\bar{h} \in \mathbb{R}^d : \#\{j \neq i : z_j^{\text{lin}}(\bar{h}) > z_i^{\text{lin}}(\bar{h})\} \leq K - 1\}.$$

705 If $\mathcal{G}_{i,K}$ contains a nonempty open set U , then by (S1) $D(U) > 0$, and $U \subseteq \mathcal{G}_{i,K}$ gives $\Pr_{\bar{h}}(\bar{h} \in$
 706 $\mathcal{G}_{i,K}) \geq D(U) > 0$. A useful sufficient condition is the existence of some $\bar{h}_0$ at which token i strictly
 707 outranks all but at most $K - 1$ other tokens in the affine surrogate; by continuity, a neighborhood of
 708 $\bar{h}_0$ is then contained in $\mathcal{G}_{i,K}$. This is a rank-changing event unreachable by the monotone temperature
 709 transform, but it does not by itself imply (M1).

710 D.3.4 Pass@ N ensemble bound (Remark)

711 The bound $\Pr(\text{Pass@}N \text{ on } x) \geq 1 - (1 - p_{\min}(x))^N$ in the main text is a standard independent-
 712 Bernoulli union argument. Let A_n be the event that the n -th run reaches a correct trajectory on x ;
 713 under (M1) $\Pr(A_n) \geq p_{\min}(x)$, and under (M2)

$$\Pr\left(\bigcap_{n=1}^N A_n^c\right) \leq (1 - p_{\min}(x))^N, \quad \Pr\left(\bigcup_{n=1}^N A_n\right) \geq 1 - (1 - p_{\min}(x))^N \geq 1 - e^{-N p_{\min}(x)}.$$

714 This is a generic fact, not specific to RSP; RSP's role is to make branch opening possible and
 715 to support (M2) through independent resampling, while whether a branch satisfies the task-side
 716 correctness condition (M1) remains task-dependent.

E Attention Mass Analysis

This appendix formalizes the per-token attention mass reported in Figure 2 and the exclusion criteria applied to the reasoning span and the layer axis. For each of the 500 MATH-500 problems, a fresh RSP $\mathbf{H} \in \mathbb{R}^{L \times d}$ with $L = 10$ is sampled independently, so the reported heatmaps average over both problem variability and RSP-vector variability.

E.1 Per-Token Attention Mass

For each problem, we measure attention on the concatenated sequence [prompt; $\mathbf{H}$; generation], where the generation is the trajectory produced by the same model under matching RSP injection. Let $\alpha_{i,j}^{(\ell,a)}$ denote the post-softmax attention weight at layer ℓ , head index a (using a to avoid collision with the RSP matrix $\mathbf{H}$), from query position i to key position j , satisfying $\sum_j \alpha_{i,j}^{(\ell,a)} = 1$ under the causal mask. Let Q and R denote the index sets of question and RSP tokens with sizes $|Q|$ and $|R| = L$, and let N_{head} be the number of heads. The per-token attention mass that query i directs to each group at layer ℓ is

$$\text{PTM}_Q[\ell, i] = \frac{1}{|Q| N_{\text{head}}} \sum_{a=1}^{N_{\text{head}}} \sum_{j \in Q} \alpha_{i,j}^{(\ell,a)}, \quad \text{PTM}_R[\ell, i] = \frac{1}{|R| N_{\text{head}}} \sum_{a=1}^{N_{\text{head}}} \sum_{j \in R} \alpha_{i,j}^{(\ell,a)}. \quad (7)$$

Normalization by $|Q|$ and $|R|$ controls for group size, so both quantities express how much attention a single question (resp. RSP) token receives on average under the same softmax denominator. Question tokens thereby serve as a size-matched baseline that absorbs sequence-length effects common to both groups.

E.2 Heatmap Aggregation

We partition the layer indices and the reasoning position indices each into five equal-size bins $\{B_L^{(b)}\}_{b=1}^5$ and $\{B_P^{(b)}\}_{b=1}^5$. For sample s and target group $\bullet \in \{Q, R\}$, the value in cell (b_L, b_P) is

$$M_{\bullet}^{(s)}[b_L, b_P] = \frac{1}{|B_L^{(b_L)}| \cdot |B_P^{(b_P)}|} \sum_{\ell \in B_L^{(b_L)}} \sum_{i \in B_P^{(b_P)}} \text{PTM}_{\bullet}[\ell, i]. \quad (8)$$

Figure 2 reports the sample average of Eq. (8) over the 500 valid samples.

E.3 Excluding the `\boxed{\dots}` Span

The reasoning position range terminates strictly before the final `\boxed{\dots}` span. Chain-of-thought outputs decompose into a *text* (content) component and a *pattern* (template) component that contribute independently to downstream performance [Madaan and Yazdanbakhsh, 2022]. The `\boxed{\dots}` wrapper is a canonical pattern: a short, stereotyped span whose role is to complete the answer format rather than to extend reasoning. Including it would therefore inject a template-driven attention signature unrelated to reasoning dynamics.

E.4 Excluding the Final Two Layers

The layer axis further excludes the last two transformer layers. This choice is motivated by a standard late-layer effect rather than by any model-specific tuning decision.

Output-projection specialization. Late-layer hidden states lie in an approximately linear relationship with vocabulary logits and therefore function as a progressive linear readout rather than as representation-transforming blocks [Belrose et al., 2023]. Consistently, late-layer feed-forward modules have been characterized as output-distribution shaping mechanisms [Geva et al., 2021]. Attention in these layers therefore reflects output formation rather than reasoning computation.

Excluding the final two layers keeps the heatmap focused on reasoning-phase dynamics instead of readout-phase dynamics. This exclusion is not load-bearing for the main claim: the sequence-direction attenuation emphasized in the main text is also visible without it, and Theorem 1 concerns sequence-direction attenuation rather than layer-wise monotonicity.

757 E.5 Additional Suffix Heatmaps

758 For the late-layer reasons discussed above, the pattern in Figure 7 does not generalize uniformly
 759 across every cell; nevertheless, the overall trend is consistent across both models: question-token
 760 attention varies broadly across layers, whereas RSP attention shows sequence-wise decay consistent
 761 with Theorem 1 alongside an empirical layer-wise attenuation that the theorem itself does not predict.

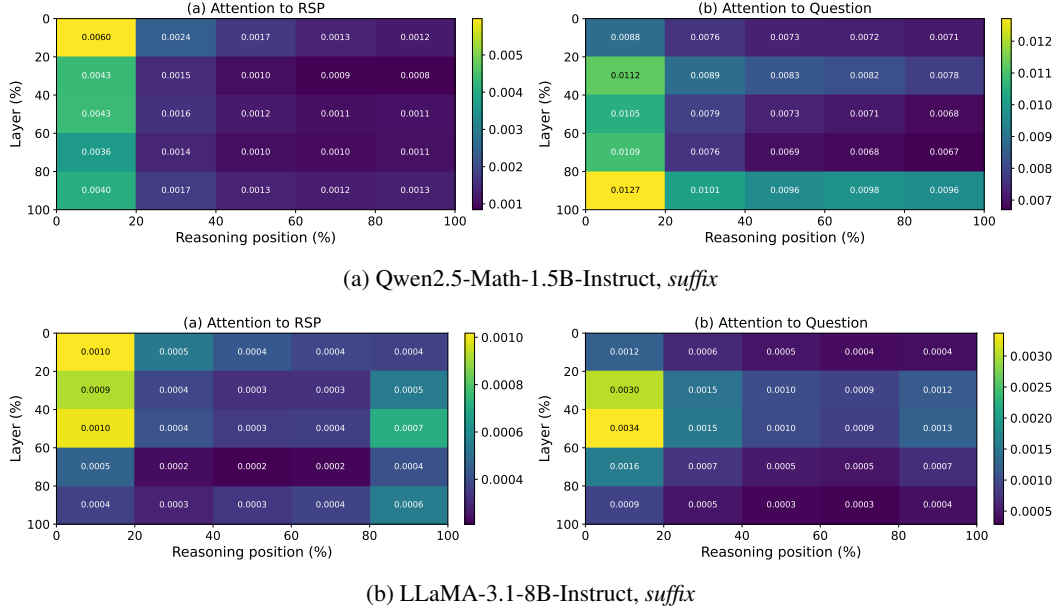


Figure 7: Per-token RSP attention mass under *suffix* injection for the remaining two models (500 MATH-500 samples each). Axes and preprocessing match Figure 2: x-axis is reasoning position binned into five quantiles, y-axis is layer depth binned into five quantiles (top = shallow), color encodes the 500-sample mean per-token attention assigned to RSP tokens, and tokens inside `\boxed{}` spans and the last two layers are excluded.

762 F DAPO Implementation

763 This appendix complements Section 5 with the DAPO loss modifications relative to GRPO, the
764 DAPO + RSP implementation, and full per-step results.

765 F.1 From GRPO to DAPO

766 The vanilla GRPO objective [Shao et al., 2024] for a group of G rollouts $\{y_i\}_{i=1}^G$ (each $y_i =$
767 $(y_{i,1}, \dots, y_{i,|y_i|})$ a token sequence; we use y rather than o throughout this appendix to avoid collision
768 with the head output $\mathbf{o}_i^{(\ell)}$ of §3.2) with rewards $\{R_i\}_{i=1}^G$ is

$$\mathcal{J}_{\text{GRPO}}(\theta) = \mathbb{E} \left[\frac{1}{G} \sum_{i=1}^G \frac{1}{|y_i|} \sum_{t=1}^{|y_i|} \left(\min(r_{i,t} \hat{A}_{i,t}, \text{clip}(r_{i,t}, 1-\varepsilon, 1+\varepsilon) \hat{A}_{i,t}) - \beta D_{\text{KL}}(\pi_\theta \| \pi_{\text{ref}}) \right) \right], \quad (9)$$

769 with importance ratio $r_{i,t} = \pi_\theta(y_{i,t} | q, y_{i,<t}) / \pi_{\theta_{\text{old}}}(y_{i,t} | q, y_{i,<t})$, group-relative advantage $\hat{A}_{i,t} =$
770 $(R_i - \text{mean}(\{R_i\})) / \text{std}(\{R_i\})$, clipping range ε , and KL penalty βD_{KL} against the reference π_{ref} .

771 We build on the SimpleRL-Zoo [Zeng et al., 2025] training pipeline and implement DAPO on
772 top of VeRL [Sheng et al., 2025]. DAPO modifies Eq. (9) in four ways: (i) token-level loss
773 aggregation $1 / \sum_i |y_i|$ instead of $1 / |y_i|$, (ii) asymmetric clipping with $(\varepsilon_{\text{low}}, \varepsilon_{\text{high}}) = (0.2, 0.28)$, (iii)
774 an implementation-side negative-advantage dual-clipping safeguard $\max(L_{\text{clipped}}, c\hat{A})$ with $c = 10$
775 (active only when $\hat{A} < 0$; omitted from Eq. (10) below for readability), and (iv) KL terms removed.
776 The resulting DAPO objective is

$$\mathcal{J}_{\text{DAPO}}(\theta) = \mathbb{E} \left[\frac{1}{\sum_i |y_i|} \sum_{i,t} \min \left(r_{i,t} \hat{A}_{i,t}, \text{clip}(r_{i,t}, 1-\varepsilon_{\text{low}}, 1+\varepsilon_{\text{high}}) \hat{A}_{i,t} \right) \right]. \quad (10)$$

777 F.2 DAPO + RSP Implementation

778 For DAPO + RSP, we additionally inject a per-rollout RSP $\mathbf{H}_i \in \mathbb{R}^{L \times d}$ ($L = 20$) into each rollout.
779 Each $\mathbf{H}_i$ is generated deterministically from a per-step rollout seed and injected via a forward hook;
780 it is not a trainable parameter, so the learning signal is the policy adapting to arbitrary $\mathbf{H}_i$ rather than
781 a learned prompt. Including $\mathbf{H}_i$ in the log-probabilities at both rollout and update time keeps the
782 update on-policy with respect to the RSP-conditioned distribution (avoiding off-policy mismatch).
783 With $G = 8$ rollouts per prompt, each rollout receives an independently drawn $\mathbf{H}_i$.

784 F.3 Data, Batch, and Hyperparameters

Table 10: DAPO / DAPO + RSP training setup on Qwen2.5-Math-7B.

Field	Value
Train data	MATH Level 3–5 subset (<code>simplelr_math_35</code> , ~8,500 prompts)
Prompt template	<code>qwen-boxed</code>
Train batch size	1024
PPO mini-batch size	256 (4 PPO updates per rollout)
Rollouts per prompt G	8
Max prompt / response length	2,028 / 2,048
Rollout sampling	temperature 1.0, top- p 1.0, top- k 50
$(\epsilon_{\text{low}}, \epsilon_{\text{high}})$	(0.2, 0.28)
Dual clip c	10.0
Loss aggregation	token-mean ($1 / \sum_i y_i $)
KL terms	disabled
Entropy coefficient	0
Optimizer	AdamW, learning rate 5×10^{-7} (constant), no warmup
Total training	~10 epochs, ≥ 80 optimization steps
Save / eval frequency	every 10 steps
RSP (DAPO + RSP only)	<i>suffix</i> injection, $L = 20$, freshly drawn per rollout
Hardware	4× NVIDIA B200 GPUs
Wall-clock training time	~12 hours per run

785 F.4 Evaluation Protocol

786 Each saved checkpoint is converted to HuggingFace format and evaluated using the SimpleRL-
787 Zoo `eval_math_nodes.sh` pipeline, which selects sampling parameters per benchmark to reduce
788 variance on the smaller competition sets:

Table 11: Per-benchmark evaluation protocol used by SimpleRL-Zoo `sh/eval.sh`.

Benchmark	# Problems	Temperature	n_{sampling}	Metric
AIME 2024	30	1.0	32	Avg@32
AMC 2023	40	1.0	32	Avg@32
MATH-500	500	0.0	1	accuracy (mean@1)
GSM8K	1,319	0.0	1	accuracy
OlympiadBench	675	0.0	1	accuracy
Minerva Math	272	0.0	1	accuracy
GaoKao 2023-EN	385	0.0	1	accuracy

789 The maximum number of generated tokens is 16,000 across all benchmarks. The reported average is
790 the unweighted mean over the five benchmarks (GSM8K, MATH-500, College Math, Minerva Math,
791 AIME 2024).

Table 12: Five-benchmark average accuracy (%) at every checkpoint, computed over GSM8K, MATH-500, College Math, Minerva Math, and AIME 2024. **Bold** marks each method’s peak.

Step	DAPO	DAPO + RSP
0	30.06	30.06
10	46.40	46.22
20	49.02	49.54
30	49.58	50.72
40	50.62	52.06
50	50.88	52.40
60	51.84	52.96
70	52.52	53.86
80	53.20	54.04
90	52.52	54.36
100	50.54	53.64

793 G Broader Impacts

794 This work provides empirical and theoretical analysis of how random embedding injection affects
795 the reasoning behavior of large language models. The contributions are primarily foundational,
796 with potential downstream implications for reinforcement learning-based post-training of reasoning
797 models such as GRPO.

798 **Positive impacts.** RSP-induced trajectory diversity could improve the sample efficiency of RL-
799 based LLM post-training by providing richer learning signals within group-relative advantage estima-
800 tion. This has the potential to reduce compute costs associated with alignment and reasoning-oriented
801 fine-tuning, making such methods more accessible to research groups with limited resources.

802 **Potential concerns.** Methods that expand the effective output support of LLMs may increase the
803 reachability of low-probability tokens, which includes both desirable alternative reasoning paths
804 and potentially unsafe or off-distribution outputs. Practitioners applying RSP in production systems
805 should combine it with existing safety filtering and alignment mechanisms rather than treating it as a
806 standalone diversity source.

807 **Limitations on impact scope.** Since this work focuses on analysis rather than deploying a new
808 model or dataset, the direct societal impact is limited. The broader implications described above are
809 contingent on future work integrating RSP into applied training pipelines.

NeurIPS Paper Checklist

1. Claims

Question: Do the main claims made in the abstract and introduction accurately reflect the paper’s contributions and scope?

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: The abstract and §1 state four scoped claims, each tied to a section: (i) RSP’s contribution at each attention layer is captured by a single scalar with a fixed-gap upper-envelope cache-growth bound (Theorem 1, §3.3); (ii) under a local affine surrogate, isotropic re-sampling reaches top- K entry regions unattainable by rank-preserving temperature sampling (§3.2); (iii) RSP raises early-token entropy and stabilizes later, with Pass@ N gains under independent re-sampling (§4); and (iv) the diversity transfers to RL training when combined with DAPO (§5). We do not claim a theorem that directly explains the format-mismatch recovery (Table 1); the wrong-attractor hypothesis there is explicitly informal.

2. Limitations

Question: Does the paper discuss the limitations of the work performed by the authors?

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: Limitations are noted in several places rather than in a dedicated section: (a) the multi-path Pass@ N argument requires the task-side assumption $p_{\min}(x) > 0$, flagged in §3.3; (b) the +18–29 pp recovery on the format-mismatch rows of Table 1 is empirically observed but not formally derived from any theorem in §3, with the EOS-derailment hypothesis stated informally in §4.2 and its quantitative verification left for future work; (c) Table 1 reports per-position accuracy across {Prefix, Suffix}, with per-position variance large and several cases below baseline, so position is treated as a hyperparameter, and the RSP length L is selected per model from {10, 15, 20} on the evaluation set with held-out validation left for future work (§6); (d) Theorem 1 guarantees only sequence-axis attenuation, while the observed layer-axis attenuation is an empirical phenomenon from deep-layer attention-logit gap sharpening that lies outside the theorem’s envelope (§6); (e) the results are confined to RoPE-based decoders and math reasoning, with generalization to other position encodings and domains left for future work (§6). The future-work items in §6, namely generalization beyond RoPE/math reasoning, deep-layer sharpening, and held-out hyperparameter selection, correspond respectively to (e), (d), and (c).

3. Theory assumptions and proofs

Question: For each theoretical result, does the paper provide the full set of assumptions and a complete (and correct) proof?

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: Theorem 1 (cache-growth attenuation) carries an inline proof in §3.3. Proposition 1 is stated in §3.2 with its proof in Appendix C; the supporting top- K entry and Pass@ N ensemble arguments around it are presented as informal discussion in §3.2 with formal write-ups in the appendix. Each statement explicitly lists its assumptions: finite logits and $n, L \geq 1$ for Theorem 1; finite second-moment budget for Proposition 1; and the locally affine surrogate plus $p_{\min}(x) > 0$ task-side condition together with mutual independence of the N runs for the Pass@ N argument.

4. Experimental result reproducibility

Question: Does the paper fully disclose all the information needed to reproduce the main experimental results of the paper to the extent that it affects the main claims and/or conclusions of the paper (regardless of whether the code and data are provided or not)?

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: §4.1 and Appendix A specify benchmarks (MATH-500, GSM8K, AIME 2024 in the main table; further sets used for the DAPO study), models (LLaMA-3.1-8B-Instruct and Qwen2.5-Math 1.5B/7B variants), the RSP injection grid (Prefix/Infix/Suffix; $L \in \{10, 15, 20\}$), greedy decoding, and the answer extraction pipeline. Appendix F provides the full DAPO + RSP training recipe (batch of 1,024 prompts, $G = 8$ rollouts per

863 prompt at $\tau = 1.0$, four PPO mini-batch updates of 256 prompts each, 100 training steps,
864 suffix RSP $L = 20$ during rollouts only).

865 **5. Open access to data and code**

866 Question: Does the paper provide open access to the data and code, with sufficient instruc-
867 tions to faithfully reproduce the main experimental results, as described in supplemental
868 material?

869 Answer: [No]

870 Justification: All datasets and base models used in the paper are publicly available and cited
871 (MATH-500, GSM8K, AIME 2024, AMC 2023, OlympiadBench, Minerva Math, GaoKao
872 2023-EN, College Math; Qwen2.5-Math 1.5B/7B and LLaMA-3.1-8B-Instruct). RSP itself
873 is described to a level of detail sufficient for re-implementation (Eq. (1) and §4.1). However,
874 our RSP injection harness and DAPO + RSP training pipeline are not yet released; we will
875 release an anonymized implementation alongside the camera-ready submission.

876 **6. Experimental setting/details**

877 Question: Does the paper specify all the training and test details (e.g., data splits, hyperpa-
878 rameters, how they were chosen, type of optimizer) necessary to understand the results?

879 Answer: [Yes]

880 Justification: §4.1 and Appendix A list all benchmarks, models, RSP injection settings
881 (positions, lengths, per-row L choice in Appendix Table 7), maximum generation length
882 per benchmark, and decoding strategy. Appendix F provides the full DAPO + RSP training
883 settings, including optimizer, batch composition, mini-batch updates, asymmetric clipping
884 range $(\varepsilon_{\text{low}}, \varepsilon_{\text{high}}) = (0.2, 0.28)$, dual clipping safeguard, and RSP injection protocol during
885 rollouts.

886 **7. Experiment statistical significance**

887 Question: Does the paper report error bars suitably and correctly defined or other appropriate
888 information about the statistical significance of the experiments?

889 Answer: [No]

890 Justification: Pass@ N experiments use $N = 16$ samples per problem (§4.4), Table 3 reports
891 mean $\pm$ standard deviation over 16 RSP seeds, and AIME 2024 is scored by Avg@32 to
892 reduce variance. However, Table 1 (Table 1) reports single-run accuracies without bootstrap
893 confidence intervals or paired tests, and the DAPO + RSP training in §5 uses a single training
894 seed. Multi-seed evaluation, particularly on small competition sets (AIME 2024, AMC
895 2023) where variance is highest, is left for future work.

896 **8. Experiments compute resources**

897 Question: For each experiment, does the paper provide sufficient information on the com-
898 puter resources (type of compute workers, memory, time of execution) needed to reproduce
899 the experiments?

900 Answer: [Yes]

901 Justification: Inference experiments (Tables 1, 2; Figure 3) run on a single NVIDIA A6000
902 40GB GPU with greedy decoding (Appendix A). DAPO + RSP training (§5) runs on 4 $\times$
903 NVIDIA B200 GPUs for approximately 12 hours per run (Appendix F, hardware row of the
904 configuration table).

905 **9. Code of ethics**

906 Question: Does the research conducted in the paper conform, in every respect, with the
907 NeurIPS Code of Ethics <https://neurips.cc/public/EthicsGuidelines?>

908 Answer: [Yes]

909 Justification: The work uses publicly available math reasoning benchmarks and pretrained
910 language models, involves no human subjects or personal data, and does not introduce a
911 release that bypasses standard model-safety considerations. We have reviewed the NeurIPS
912 Code of Ethics and identify no conflicts.

913 **10. Broader impacts**

914 Question: Does the paper discuss both potential positive societal impacts and negative
915 societal impacts of the work performed?

916 Answer: [Yes]

917 Justification: Appendix G discusses both directions: positive impact via more sample-
918 efficient RL post-training of reasoning LLMs, and a potential downside that broadening the
919 effective output support also increases reachability of undesirable trajectories, which we
920 argue should keep RSP coupled with existing safety filtering rather than replacing it.

921 **11. Safeguards**

922 Question: Does the paper describe safeguards that have been put in place for responsible
923 release of data or models that have a high risk for misuse (e.g., pre-trained language models,
924 image generators, or scraped datasets)?

925 Answer: [N/A]

926 Justification: The paper does not release new pretrained models, generative systems, or
927 scraped datasets. RSP is a generation-time perturbation applied to existing pretrained models
928 and introduces no separate artifact requiring safeguards.

929 **12. Licenses for existing assets**

930 Question: Are the creators or original owners of assets (e.g., code, data, models), used in
931 the paper, properly credited and are the license and terms of use explicitly mentioned and
932 properly respected?

933 Answer: [Yes]

934 Justification: All datasets (MATH-500 [Lightman et al., 2024], GSM8K [Cobbe et al., 2021],
935 AIME 2024, AMC 2023, OlympiadBench [He et al., 2024], Minerva Math [Lewkowycz
936 et al., 2022], GaoKao 2023-EN, College Math) and pretrained models (Qwen2.5-Math
937 [Yang et al., 2024], LLaMA-3.1 [Grattafiori et al., 2024]) are publicly available and cited
938 at first use. The training pipeline builds on SimpleRL-Zoo [Zeng et al., 2025] and VeRL
939 [Sheng et al., 2025], also cited. Each asset is used under its original publicly stated terms.

940 **13. New assets**

941 Question: Are new assets introduced in the paper well documented and is the documentation
942 provided alongside the assets?

943 Answer: [N/A]

944 Justification: The paper does not release new datasets or pretrained models. The implemen-
945 tation code planned for camera-ready release (item 5) will be accompanied by configuration
946 files and a README; no derived dataset or model checkpoint is part of the submission.

947 **14. Crowdsourcing and research with human subjects**

948 Question: For crowdsourcing experiments and research with human subjects, does the paper
949 include the full text of instructions given to participants and screenshots, if applicable, as
950 well as details about compensation (if any)?

951 Answer: [N/A]

952 Justification: The paper involves no crowdsourcing and no research with human subjects.
953 All evaluations use static, publicly available math reasoning benchmarks.

954 **15. Institutional review board (IRB) approvals or equivalent for research with human
955 subjects**

956 Question: Does the paper describe potential risks incurred by study participants, whether
957 such risks were disclosed to the subjects, and whether Institutional Review Board (IRB)
958 approvals (or an equivalent approval/review based on the requirements of your country or
959 institution) were obtained?

960 Answer: [N/A]

961 Justification: As noted in item 14, the paper involves no human subjects, so IRB review is
962 not applicable.

963 **16. Declaration of LLM usage**

964 Question: Does the paper describe the usage of LLMs if it is an important, original, or
965 non-standard component of the core methods in this research? Note that if the LLM is used
966 only for writing, editing, or formatting purposes and does *not* impact the core methodology,
967 scientific rigor, or originality of the research, declaration is not required.

968 Answer: [N/A]

969 Justification: Pretrained LLMs (Qwen2.5-Math, LLaMA-3.1) appear in the paper as the
970 experimental subject of analysis, not as a non-standard component of the methods themselves.
971 The methods (RSP definition, attention decomposition, DAPO + RSP training) do not rely
972 on auxiliary LLMs in any non-standard or originality-affecting role.